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Liver

The liver, the largest gland in our body is situated in the upper right side of the abdominal cavity, just below the diaphragm. The liver consists of two major left and right lobes; and two minor lobes. These lobes are connected with diaphragm. Each lobe has many hepatic lobules (functional unit of liver) and is covered by a thin connective tissue sheath called the **Glisson's capsule**. Liver cells (hepatic cells) secrete bile which is stored and concentrated in a thin muscular sac called the gall bladder. The duct of gall bladder (cystic duct) along with the hepatic duct from the liver forms the common bile duct. The bile duct passes downwards and joins with the main pancreatic duct to form a common duct called hepato-pancreatic duct. The opening of the hepato-pancreatic duct into the duodenum is guarded by a sphincter called the **sphincter of Oddi** (Figure.5.7). Liver has high power of regeneration and liver cells are replaced by new ones every 3-4 weeks.

Apart from bile secretion, the liver also performs several functions

1. Destroys aging and defective blood cells
2. Stores glucose in the form of glycogen or disperses glucose into the blood stream with the help of pancreatic hormones
3. Stores fat soluble vitamins and iron
4. Detoxifies toxic substances.
5. Involves in the synthesis of non-essential amino acids and urea.

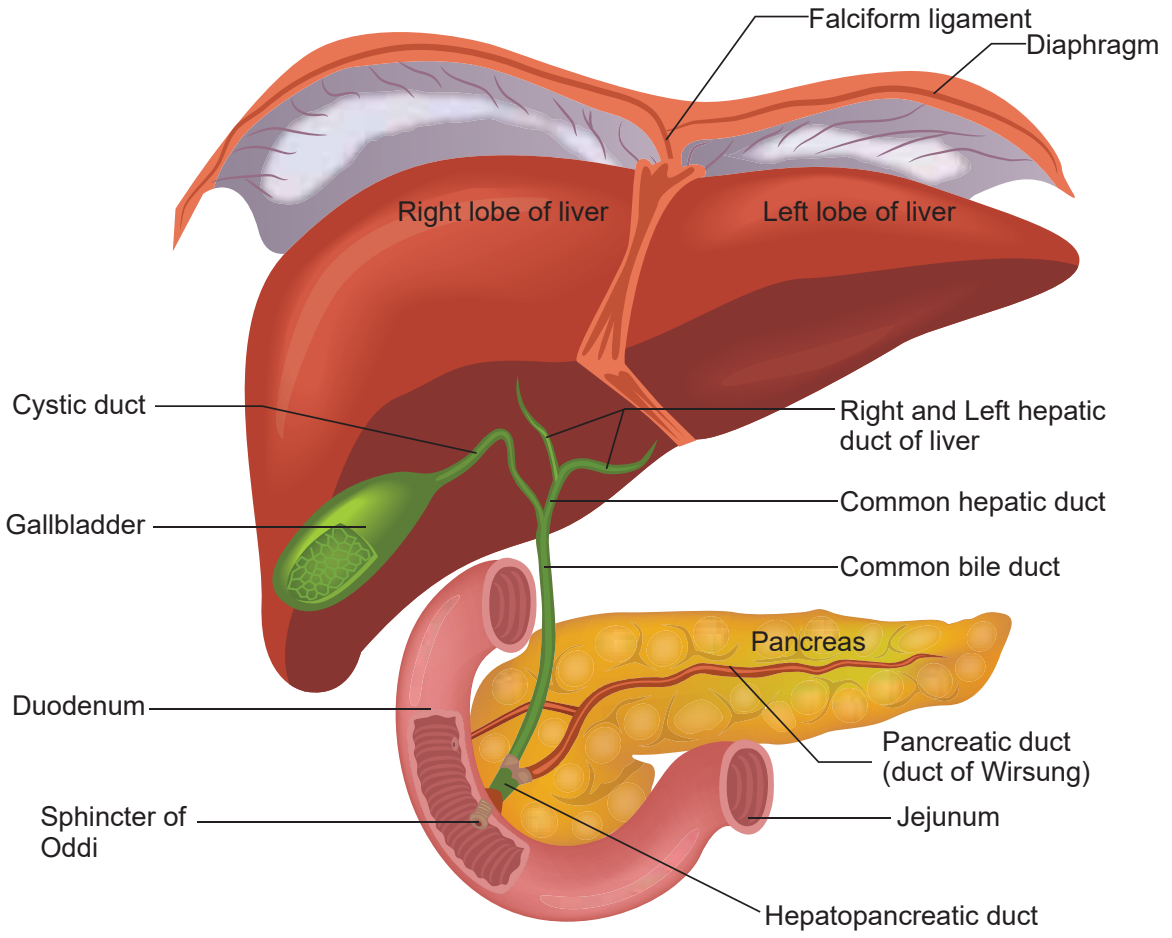


Figure 5.7 Liver and pancreas